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**POET VERSUS MINISTER AND MONK:
SU SHI ON STAGE IN THE PERIOD 1250-1450**

BY

W.L. IDEMA

I. Introduction

Su Shi 蘇軾 (1036–1101) was quite a popular figure on the early Chinese stage.¹ But that popularity was limited to a specific dramatic genre, *zaju* 雜劇. From the Yuan and early Ming dynasties we know at least seven titles of *zaju* that deal with an episode from the life of this Northern Song dynasty poet, and three of these plays have come down to us. These three plays are *Bian Huangzhou* 貶黃州 (Banished to Huangzhou) by Fei Tangchen 費唐臣; the anonymous *Chibi fu* 赤壁賦 (Red Cliff Rhapsody); and *Dongpo meng* 東坡夢 (Dongpo's Dream), which is attributed to Wu Changling 吳昌齡. As *zaju* was primarily the dramatic genre of Northern China, this implies that Su's stage popularity had a clear regional character. This probably already predated the Yuan dynasty. The *Yuanben mingmu* 院本名目, a catalogue of Jin dynasty farces, includes a *Foyin shao zhu* 佛印燒豬 (Foyin Roasts Pork) and a *Bai Mudan* 白牡丹. These two farces are evidently named after characters which also make an appearance in *Dongpo meng*.² By contrast, none of the titles in the catalogue of Southern Song farces, *Guanben zaju duanmu* 官本雜劇段目, can be connected with the figure of Su Shi.³ None of the titles of *xiwen* 戲文, the early Southern drama, would appear to have dealt with his life

¹ This paper is not intended as a contribution to the biography of Su Shi, though it may be of use to the study of his reputation after his death. The most extensive western-language biography of Su Shi is still Lin Yutang, *The Gay Genius, The Life and Times of Su Tungpo* (New York: John Day, 1947). The image of Su Shi in Lin's book is characterized as "a cultural teddy-bear" by George C. Hatch in his quite detailed biographical sketch of Su Shi, in Herbert Franke ed., *Sung Biographies* (Wiesbaden: Franz Steiner, 1976), pp.900–68. Su Shi's popularity on the stage was already pointed out by Yoshikawa Kôjirô 吉川幸次郎 in his *Gen zatsugeki kenkyû* 元雜劇研究 (in *Yoshikawa Kôjirô zenshû*, Vol. XIV, Tokyo: Chikuma shobô, 1978), pp.206–07.

² Tao Zongyi 陶宗儀, *Nancun chuogeng lu* 南村輟耕錄 (Peking: Zhonghua shuju, (1959, 1980), pp.306–15; Hu Ji 胡忌, *Song Jin zaju kao* 宋金雜劇考 (Peking: Zhonghua shuju, 1959), pp. 171–87, p.217, p.219.

³ Zhou Mi 周密, *Wulin jiushi* 武林舊事, in Meng Yuanlao a.o., *Dongjing meng Hua lu wai si zhong* (Peking: Zhonghua shuju, 1962), pp.508–12; Hu Ji, *Song Jin zaju kao* (Peking: 1959), pp.159–71.

either.⁴ However, Su Shi is not completely absent from early vernacular literature from the South. Both he and Foyin figure in the vernacular story *Wujie chanshi si Honglian ji* 五戒禪師私紅蓮記 (How the Monk Wujie Abused Red Lotus), a remarkably inept *huaben* 話本 which most probably was written at Hangchow in the first century of the Ming dynasty. In this *huaben* Su Shi and Foyin are described as the reincarnations of the monks Wujie and Mingwu 明悟, whose relationship takes up most of the tale.⁵

The regional nature of Su's stage popularity was most likely a reflection of Su Shi's contrasting reputation among the literati north and south of the Huai during the twelfth and thirteenth centuries. Under the Northern Song dynasty, Su Shi was not only considered a major poet, but a major thinker as well. Under the Southern Song dynasty, his brand of Neo-Confucianism increasingly lost favour while Zhu Xi's grand summation established itself as the orthodoxy of the future. The writings of Zhu Xi and his school were not completely unknown in contemporary northern China but exerted little influence there for the duration of the Jin dynasty, and this situation did not change until the completion of the Mongol conquest of the South, when *zaju* was already a well-established genre. To Jin dynasty literati, Su Shi remained *the* exemplary exponent of Confucianism. This is clearly brought out in the following conversation between emperor Shizong (reigned 1161–1189) and Yelü Li 耶律履 (1121–1191) as recorded by Yuan Haowen 元好問 (1190–1257):

Shizong once asked who had been the most excellent among the famous officials of the Song dynasty. Yelü Li replied that it was the academician of the Duanming Hall Su Shi. Shizong said: "I have been told that Su Shi and the commandant-escort Wang Shen 王詵 were very close friends. And when writing songs he even went so far as to flirt with the princess—is that not the utmost of impropriety? How is such a man worthy to be mentioned?" Yelü Li replied: "Stories and rumours are not necessarily credible. But even if it had happened, why should he severely be taken to task for a little joke? How could one negate such a man because of it? Your Majesty, do not slight the words of a wise minister because you believe stories

⁴ Cf. Qian Nanyang 錢南揚 ed., *Song Yuan xiwen ji*'i 宋元戲文輯佚 (Shanghai: Shanghai gudian wenxue chubanshe, 1956); Qian Nanyang, *Xiwen gailun* 戲文概論 (Shanghai: Shanghai guji chubanshe, 1981), pp.73–83.

⁵ For the text of this *huaben* see Hong Bian 洪楸 comp., *Qingping shantang huaben* 清平山堂話本 (Peking: Wenxue guji kanxingshe, 1955), pp.229–46; and Hong Bian comp., *Qingping shantang huaben*, coll. and ann. by Tan Zhengbi 譚正璧 (Shanghai: Gudian wenxue chubanshe, 1957), pp.136–54. Cf. Patrick Hanan, *The Chinese Short Story, Studies in Dating, Authorship, and Composition* (Cambridge, Mass.: Harvard Univ. Press, 1973), p. 235; and André Lévy, *Inventaire analytique et critique du conte chinois en langue vulgaire, Première partie, premier volume* (Paris: Presses universitaires de France, 1978), pp.57–60.

and rumours!” The next day he copied Su’s memorials and presented them to the throne, whereupon the directorate of education was ordered to print and publish them.”⁶

The above anecdote testifies both to Su Shi’s high reputation among scholars of the Jin and to the continuous development of the lore surrounding him.

II. *Banished to Huangzhou*

Su Zizhan fengxue bian Huangzhou 蘇子瞻風雪貶黃州 (Su Zizhan in a Snowstorm Banished to Huangzhou) is the only surviving play by Fei Tangchen.⁷ Biographical information about him is extremely scarce. Zhong Sicheng 鍾嗣成, in his *Lu gui bu* 錄鬼簿, lists him in the category of “Famous lords and poets of the former generation who have already passed away and whose plays circulate in the world” and can only add “A man from Dadu, the son of Junxiang.”⁸ Fei Tangchen’s father, Fei Junxiang 費君祥, is listed in the same category. In his case the biographical notice reads: “A man from Dadu, the father of Tangchen and a friend of [Guan] Hanqing 關漢卿. His *Ainü lun* 愛女論 (Treatise on How to Love Women) circulates in the world.”⁹ This *Ainü lun* would appear to have been lost, as is the case with the only play credited to him, *Cai zi jia ren ju hua hui* 才子佳人菊花會 (Poet and Beauty: Chrysanthemum Meeting).¹⁰ In view of the above, we may conclude that Fei Tangchen, as a younger member of the first generation of *zaju* playwrights, was active in Dadu in the final decades of the thirteenth century.

The early cataloguers agree in crediting Fei Tangchen with the authorship of three plays. Judging from their titles the two lost plays must, like *Bian Huangzhou*, have dealt with the vicissitudes of a bureaucratic career. *Zhan Deng Tong* 斬鄧通 (The Beheading of Deng Tong) must have dealt with the career and downfall of this notorious favourite of the Han emperor Wendi. *Han chengxiang Wei Xian ying jin* 漢丞相韋賢贏金 (Counselor-in-chief of the Han dynasty Wei Xian: A Basketful of Gold) must have treated the careers of

⁶ Yuan Haowen, “Shangshu youchengxiang Yelü gong shendao bei” 尚書右丞相耶律公神道碑, in *Yuan Yishan xiansheng ji* 元遺山先生集 ch. XXVII (in Wu Zhongxi comp., *Jiu Jinren ji*, repr. Taipei: Chengwen chubanshe, 1967), p.893.

⁷ Fu Xihua 傅惜華, *Yundai zaju quanmu* 元代雜劇全目 (Peking: Zuojia chubanshe, 1957), pp.202–03.

⁸ Zhong Sicheng, *Lu gui bu* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng* (Peking: Zhongguo xiju chubanshe, 1959), Vol. II), p. 113.

⁹ *Op. cit.*, p.116.

¹⁰ Fu Xihua, *Yundai zaju quanmu* (Peking: 1957), p.81.

Wei Xian (148–60 B.C.) and his son, who both attained the high office of *chengxiang*. Jia Zhongming 賈仲明 praises the latter play for its brilliant plot (*guanmu huiguang* 關目輝光) and the former for its clear lyrics (*wenci liang* 文詞亮), which suggests that these *zaju* were still available for inspection in the early fifteenth century.¹¹ However, it may well be the high seriousness of the subject-matter of all Fei's works, rather than their literary qualities, which earned him the remarkably high position in Zhu Quan's 朱權 evaluative classification of Yuan dynasty play- and song-writers in the *Taihe zhengyin pu* 太和正音譜. In this list of 187 persons Fei Tangchen is assigned the sixth place, following e.g. Ma Zhiyuan 馬致遠 and Bai Pu 白樸, but preceding e.g. such luminaries as Wang Shifu 王實甫, Guan Hanqing and Zheng Dehui 鄭德輝.¹² In its formulary of *qu* 曲, the *Taihe zhengyin pu* includes five arias from *Bian Huangzhou* (seven if one counts the repeats (*yao* 么) separately).¹³

The only edition of *Bian Huangzhou* which has come down to us is a manuscript copy in *Maiwangguan chaojiaoben gujin zaju* 脈望觀鈔校本古今雜劇.¹⁴ The contents of this *zaju* may be summarized as follows:

Act I, Scene 1. Prime minister Wang Anshi 王安石 (no role-type specified), angered by Su Shi's opposition to his New Laws, has instructed the censor Li Ding 李定 to accuse Su Shi of lèse-majesté in his poetry.

Scene 2. The emperor (*jia* 駕), though furious about Su's opposition to the New Laws, cherishes his talents. The censor Li Ding (no role-type specified) enters and reads his memorial against Su, in which he quotes incriminating lines. The emperor orders Su to be arrested and tried.

Scene 3. The former prime minister Zhang Wending 張文定 (no role-type specified) decides to see the emperor in order to defend Su.

Scene 4. The emperor, whose anger has abated in the meantime, is asked by Zhang to reinstate Su Shi in his original post. The emperor has Su summoned. Upon entering Su Shi (*zhengmo* 正末) remembers his former glory and contrasts it with his present situation. When he appears before the throne, the emperor announces his verdict: banishment to Huangzhou. Su Shi protests his innocence and loyal purpose. The emperor and Zhang urge him to acquiesce and Su can only lament his misfortune.

Act II, Scene 5. In Huangzhou, the retired upright official Ma Zhengqing 馬正卿 (no role-type specified), attended by a page, awaits the arrival of Su Shi. Su,

¹¹ Zhong Sicheng, *Lu gui bu* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, Vol. II), p.187, note 466.

¹² Zhu Quan, *Taihe zhengyin pu* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, Vol. III), p.17.

¹³ *Op. cit.*, p.67, p.88, p.105.

¹⁴ *Maiwangguan chaojiaoben gujin zaju* has been photomechanically reproduced in *Guben xiqu congkan*, Fourth Series. The first modern type-set edition of *Bian Huangzhou* has been provided by Wang Jilie, in *Guben Yuan Ming zaju* 孤本元明雜劇 (Peking: Zhongguo xiju chubanshe, 1958).

attended by a page, enters. A heavy snow is falling and his page urges him to hurry on. Su in his songs describes the snow, and contrasts his former glory with his present misery.

Su is greeted by Ma, who offers him a cup of wine and asks for a poem. Su refuses the request because poetry has been the cause of his downfall. When Ma insists on the injustice of his banishment, Su repeatedly claims to look forward to the simple life in the country and to have no desire to return to Court.

Act III, Scene 6. Ma Zhengqing is worried that the local prefect Yang 楊, a student of Wang Anshi, will refuse to aid Su Shi.

Scene 7. Wang Anshi has written a letter to prefect Yang, instructing him not to provide any help to Su Shi.

Scene 8. Prefect Yang (*jing* 淨) intends to follow Wang's instructions.

Su Shi enters, with wife and child. He complains about their present poverty, compares it to their former luxury, and ponders the fickleness of the creator. The child asks for food, his wife confirms they have no rice left in the house. Su decides to go and beg for some food, whereupon his wife and child exit.

Su appears at the prefect's yamen and is admitted. He requests help from Yang but is berated at length, and the gate-keeper is bastinadoed for letting him in. Then Yang c.s. exit.

Su laments his fate but is urged by the gate-keeper to take himself away. After further consideration of his poor luck, Su voices his confidence that eventually he will be recalled because of his talents.

Wedge. Scene 9. After several years, the emperor has decided to have Su Shi recalled to court.

Scene 10. Su Shi has received the summons to return to court. He recalls the help he has received from Ma Zhengqing. Ma and prefect Yang enter, together with villagers and musicians, to see him off. Yang offers his apologies. Su expresses his joy over his recall.

Act IV, Scene 11. The emperor is waiting for the arrival of Su Shi. The emissary who has fetched him announces his arrival.

Su Shi enters in full court dress. He ponders the fickleness of fate and appears before the emperor. He narrates his miseries, but when requested to do so, he refuses to chant any of his Huangzhou compositions or to improvise a poem, because his poetry was the cause of his misfortune.

Ma and Yang are summoned and enter. Ma is appointed as metropolitan prefect, Yang is demoted to the status of commoner despite Su's protest that Yang's behaviour was only normal.

The emperor reinstates Su in his former post of academician of the Duanming Hall, but Su declines the appointment: he now prefers the joys of a simple life in the country.

In *Bian Huangzhou* the one singing role has been assigned to Su Shi. His four suites of songs respectively employ the modes *Xianlü*, *Zhenggung*, *Yuediao* and *Shuangdiao*. The single song of the Wedge is written to the tune *Shanghua shi*; it is also to be sung by Su Shi.

The first modern editor of this play, Wang Jilie 王季烈, praised its songs highly and even went so far as to exclaim "Of the presently preserved more than three hundred *zaju* by Yuan and early Ming

authors, this play may be called the last word of perfection!"¹⁵ As often, Wang was probably carried away by his enthusiasm upon the rediscovery of a presumably lost text. The authors of the entry on Fei Tangchen in the drama section of the *Encyclopedia Sinica* formulate a more balanced opinion: "This play forcefully describes the dangers of a bureaucratic career and the fickleness of common feelings. It gives vent to the emotions of anger of a wronged intellectual element. Act II describes the feelings of the [main] character during a snowstorm; it fuses scene and emotion and has an intense poetic mood. It deepens the characterization of the protagonist and manifests the playwright's special lyrical qualities. But the play lacks a central dramatic conflict and its construction is rather loose."¹⁶

Bian Huangzhou was not unique in treating the theme of an official's banishment. Actually, the theme was quite popular with playwrights of the Yuan and early Ming dynasties, as perhaps might only be expected in view of its dramatic potential and its central place in serious poetry. Accordingly, Zhu Quan, in his twelve-fold division of the subject-matter of *zaju*, established the category *zhuchen guzi* 逐臣孤子 (exiled officials and orphaned sons).¹⁷ The best known play on an "orphaned son" is of course Ji Junxiang's 紀君祥 *Zhaoshi gu'er* 趙氏孤兒 (The Orphan of the Zhao Clan), which at first sight may appear to be a world apart from a play like *Bian Huangzhou*. The common element is, of course, that in both cases we are dealing with tales of adversity, in which people are barred by their enemies from the high social position which, because of birth and breeding, talents and virtue, is their due. This category should probably also include the group of structurally very similar plays on promising students who are deliberately humiliated by their patrons in order to spur them on to still greater effort, e.g. Zheng Dehui's *Wang Can denglou* 王粲登樓 (Wang Can Ascends the Tower). Modern studies on thematic subgenres of *zaju*, however, have only rarely dealt with these plays as a group.¹⁸

The best-known cases of banishment are those of poets because they immortalized their misfortune in their compositions. Most *zaju* on banishment, accordingly, treat the banishment of famous

¹⁵ Wang Jilie, *Guben Yuan Ming zaju* (Peking: 1958), "Tiyao", pp.8a-b.

¹⁶ *Zhongguo da baike quanshu, Xiqu, quyi* 中國大百科全書戲曲曲藝 (Peking/Shanghai: Zhongguo da baike quanshu chubanshe, 1983), p.72.

¹⁷ Zhu Quan, *Taihe zhengyin pu* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, Vol. III), p.24.

¹⁸ Chung-wen Shih, *The Golden Age of Chinese Drama: Yuan Tsa-chü* (Princeton: Princeton Univ. Press, 1976) ignores "banishment" in her discussion of "Confucian Themes" (pp.81-91) and discusses plays which belong to the "*Wang Can deng lou* group" under the heading of "friendship".

writers. Basically, the playwrights treating banishment could choose between two approaches to the subject. Either they could choose to focus on the circumstances leading up to the banishment and conclude with a description of exile, or they might start out with the miseries of life in exile and conclude on the happy note of a recall to the capital. The latter approach was of course far more congenial to the festive function of traditional Chinese theatre, but the first approach might be unavoidable if the protagonist's banishment had ended in death or suicide. The most famous banished official in all of Chinese history is Qu Yuan 屈原, who, according to tradition, eventually committed suicide by drowning himself in the river Miluo. In the early fourteenth century both Sui Shunchen 睢舜臣 and Wu Hongdao 吳弘道 devoted a *zaju* to him with the title *Chu dafu Qu Yuan tou Jiang* 楚大夫屈原投江 (The Grand Master of Chu Qu Yuan Jumps into the River).¹⁹ As both plays have been lost, we do not know how their authors solved the tricky problem of writing up a suicide into a happy ending, but perhaps they followed the lead of Wang Bocheng's 王伯成 *Li Taibai bian Yelang* 李太白貶夜郎 (Li Taibai is Banished to Yelang).²⁰ In Wang's play, the first three acts are taken up by a description of Li Taibai's experiences at the court of the emperor Xuanzong 玄宗: admitted into the private apartments of the palace he observes the shameless carrying on between Yang Guifei 楊貴妃 and An Lushan 安祿山. The fourth act takes place after the rebellion of An Lushan and portrays a banished Li Taibai, travelling through the deep South and paying a dream-visit to the subaqueous palaces of the dragon-gods. This *zaju* is concluded by a final demi-act, in which a pardoned Li Taibai, during a celebration with friends, tries to grasp the moon's reflection on the water. Unfortunately, *Li Taibai bian Yelang* has only been preserved in a Yuan printing, which causes many difficulties in interpretation.²¹

¹⁹ Fu Xihua, *Yuandai zaju quanmu* (Peking, 1957), pp.231–32 and pp.252–53. Wu Hongdao is credited with five plays, none of which have been preserved. Sui Shunchen is credited with three *zaju*, which have all been lost, but he is also the author of the famous burlesque *sangqu* suite *Gaozu huanxiang* 高祖還鄉 (Gaozu Returns), which describes the grand procession of the first emperor of the Han dynasty visiting his native village, as seen through the eyes of a country bumpkin. Laurence A. Schneider, *A Madman of Ch'u, The Chinese Myth of Loyalty and Dissent* (Berkeley: Univ. of California Press, 1980), pp.79–83 discusses some short *zaju* on Qu Yuan from the second half of the Ming dynasty.

²⁰ *Op. cit.*, p.149. *Bian Yelang* is the only play to survive of Wang Bocheng's three *zaju*. Wang also dealt with the events of Xuanzong's reign in his *Tianbao yishi zhugongdiao* 天寶遺事諸宮調 (The All-keys-and-modes on the Anecdotes of the Tianbao Era) of which some fifty song-suites survive.

²¹ For type-set editions of *Bian Yelang*, see Zheng Qian 鄭騫 coll., *Jiaoding Yuan*

In the cases of Han Yu 韓愈 and Bai Juyi 白居易 the period of exile came to an end with a recall to the capital. Han Yu was demoted twice in his long career, but only his banishment to Chaozhou in 819 captivated the popular mind. His opposition to Buddhism endeared him to the Taoists. His distant nephew Xiang 湘, who met him at the snow-blocked Lan Pass to become the addressee of the well-known poem *Zuoqian zhi Languan shi zhisun Xiang* 左遷至藍關示侄孫湘 (Banished I arrived at Lan Pass, for my distant nephew Xiang), developed into Han Xiangzi 韓湘子, one of the Eight Immortals, who delivers his uncle. This legend was twice adapted for the stage as a *zaju*, but both versions have been lost. Zhao Mingdao 趙明道 wrote *Han Tuizhi xueyong Languan ji* 韓退之雪擁藍關記 (Han Yu Blocked by Snow on Lan Pass)²² and Ji Junxiang entitled his work *Han Xiangzi sandu Han Tuizhi* 韓湘子三渡韓退之 (Han Xiangzi Thrice Delivers Han Yu).²³ Especially in this latter case, the title makes it very clear that Han Yu's banishment must have been treated in the manner of a deliverance play, with a threefold confrontation between the deliverer and his disciple-to-be. We cannot be very far off the mark if we speculate that the third act climax must have been the meeting of Han Xiangzi and Han Yu at Lan Pass, where Han Yu would have had occasion to recite the poem referred to earlier.

Of the many poems written by Bai Juyi during his period of banishment at Jiangzhou (modern Jiujiang), probably none has become more popular than his *Pipa xing* 琵琶行 (Ballad of the Lute). In this relatively long narrative poem, Bai recounts a meeting with a travelling merchant's abandoned wife, a former courtesan, for whose plight he feels a deep sympathy. *Pipa xing* inspired Ma Zhiyuan to write his play *Qingshan lei* 青衫淚 (Tears on a Blue Gown), preserved in five different late Ming editions.²⁴ This *zaju* is a scholar-and-courtesan play, and its plot is closely modelled on the tale, extremely popular in Yuan times, of Shuang Jian 雙漸 and Su Xiaoqing 蘇小卿: while in the capital, Bai Juyi falls in love with a courtesan, who, after his banishment from the capital, is sold against her will to a travelling Jiangxi tea-merchant. The climax of the play is act III, when Bai Juyi by chance meets her again, attracted by the sadness of her lute-playing: this act first dramatizes the events narrated

kan zaju sanshi zhong 校訂元刊雜劇三十種 (Taipei: Shijie shuju, 1962), pp.243–58 and Xu Qunjun 許沁君 coll., *Xinjian Yuan kan zaju sanshi zhong* 新校元刊雜劇三十種 (Peking: Zhonghua shuju, 1980), pp.436–64.

²² Fu Xihua, *Tuandai zaju quanmu* (Peking, 1959), p.141.

²³ *Op. cit.*, p.116.

²⁴ *Op. cit.*, p.69.

in the *Pipa xing*, and next has Bai Juyi recite the full text of this poem! In the final act of *Qingshan lei* Bai Juyi and the female protagonist are reunited by imperial decision.²⁵

Su Shi's banishment to Huangzhou, as treated by Fei Tangchen, rather invokes comparison with the stage exile of Han Yu and Bai Juyi than with the banishment of Qu Yuan or Li Taibai. As soon as we do indeed compare *Bian Huangzhou* to *Qingshan lei* (and *Han Xiangzi sandu Han Tuizhi*) two points of contrast stand out. The first of these is the matter of plot, the second is the treatment of the protagonist's poetry of exile. The sample to which we compare *Bian Huangzhou* may be too small to enable us to speak of "generic characteristics" but it would appear that plays on banishment do not share a distinctive plot structure like deliverance plays or scholar-and-courtesan plays, but that they might develop their own meagre plot of exile and recall by freely borrowing from other subgenres of *zaju* as long as they managed to give prominent exposure to their protagonist's poetry of exile in the climatic third act. However, Fei Tangchen did neither. In *Bian Huangzhou* he did not incorporate any plot elements from other subgenres and he also chose to ignore Su Shi's extremely well-known poetry of exile, e.g. the two *Red Cliff Rhapsodies*.

The few modern scholars who have discussed *Bian Huangzhou* have all noted the remarkable degree to which Fei Tangchen adhered to the historical record, implicitly or explicitly contrasting his adaptation to the blatantly ahistorical fictions of *Qingshan lei* and *Chibi fu*.²⁶ Fei attributes Wang Anshi's antagonism towards Su Shi to the latter's opposition to Wang's New laws. As often (cf. *Zhaoshi gu'er*) such fatal antagonism is simply stated at the opening of the play as the cause of the ensuing action, and not further explored. Wang Anshi does not directly engage Su Shi but works through his stooges, Li Ding and prefect Yang. The accusation by Li Ding of *lèse-majesté*, the interferences of Zhang Wending, the banishment to Huangzhou, Su Shi's poverty there and the help received from Ma Zhengqing, and Su's eventual recall to the capital – all these elements have a sound historical basis and are treated, making allowance for the unavoidable simplification involved in a

²⁵ This summary is based on the edition of *Qingshan lei* in Zang Jinshu 臧晉叔 comp., *Yuanqu xuan* (Peking: Zhonghua shuju, 1958), pp.882–99. This play has been translated into English by Shao-ling Yu as "Tears on the Blue Gown, by Ma Chih-yuan (fl. 1251)", in *Renditions X* (1978), pp.131–54.

²⁶ Wang Jilie, *Guben Yuan Ming zaju* (Peking 1958), "Tiyao", pp.8a-b; Yan Dunyi, *Yuanju zhenyi* 元劇斟疑 (Peking: Zhonghua shuju, 1960), p.743; Luo Jintang 羅錦堂, *Xiancun Yuanren zaju benshi kao* 現存元人雜劇本事考 (Taibei: Zhongguo wenhua shiye, 1960), pp.126–27.

stage adaptation, with great fidelity. In so doing, Fei Tangchen has constructed a play which gradually discloses the full personality of its protagonist under the increasingly taxing circumstances of degradation (act I), deprivation (act II), humiliation (act III) – and reinstatement (act IV)! But for all his fidelity to historical detail, Fei Tangchen drastically departs from history in his conclusion: when, in act IV, Su Shi is reinstated in his former office, he politely but resolutely declines and opts for the joys of a simple life in the country. The historical Su Shi may, during his exile, have achieved a higher degree of awareness of the relative value of all things in this world, he continued his official career upon his return to the centre of imperial power (as we know, only to be banished again, as far as Hainan island). Fei Tangchen's Su Shi has experienced the ways of the world to the full and, once he is vindicated, decides to retire from it.

This refusal to serve is paralleled by an equally ahistorical negation of poetry on the part of Su. Wang Anshi instructs Li Ding to make use of Su's poetry in order to accuse him of *lèse-majesté*. And so Li Ding's memorial reads: "Discussing the New Laws he (i.e. Su Shi) calumniates the present prime minister; in his poetry he vilifies the Court", and next proceeds to quote specific lines of poetry, explaining their implied purpose. (The examples are quoted from Shu Dan's 舒亶 memorial against Su Shi, except the first: the poem on the "Old Scholar tree").²⁷ When thereupon Zhang Wending intervenes with the emperor on behalf of Su, he does so by quoting the "Great Preface" of the *Book of Odes*: "Moreover, poetry requires subtle reproof – they who recite it do commit no crime, those who hear it may be warned by it."²⁸ If this exonerates the poet, it also reaffirms the political nature of poetry. When Su Shi appears before the emperor in act I, he does not deny the political nature of his poetry; he merely protests the moral correctness of his political position and aligns himself with all earlier authors who were banished because of their writings. If poetry is one aspect of public political action, the option for a private life, far from the court and its power struggles, entails a negation of poetry. And so, when in act II Ma Zhengqing requests a poem from Su Shi, he refuses:

([The *mo* (i.e. Su Shi)] sings:)
[*Daigu duo*]

²⁷ *Bian Huangzhou* (in Wang Jilie, *Guben Yuan Ming zaju*, Peking, 1958), p.1b, and Peng Jiuwan 朋九萬 comp., *Dongpo Wutai shi'an* 東坡烏臺詩案 (in *Congshu jicheng* No. 783) p.2.

²⁸ *Bian Huangzhou* (in Wang Jilie, *Guben Yuan Ming zaju*, Peking 1958), p.2a.

The young boy and the old man, I observe, offer me fragrant wine,
But how should I not have seen through the lust for wine, the madness of poetry?

(Ma speaks:)

For a long time I have heard about your great talent. Please instruct me with a beautiful composition.

(The *mo* speaks:)

Sir, I'll drink the wine but don't mention poetry again!

(Ma speaks:)

Poetry and wine are part of our life. What does your present journey have to do with poetry and wine?

(The *mo* sings:)

It is not that I forgot my home because of wine,
At this moment I suffer exile on account of my poems.
The craze for wine is just a common matter,
The passion for poetry is my life-long wish.
But why am I banished over thousands of miles?
That's why I fear to improvise poems without end!²⁹

And arias follow on the pleasures of anonymity: "My heart does not long for a purple gown and golden belt, / I have a mind to wear a bamboo hat and straw cape."³⁰ Poetic declarations of personal purity and undiminished loyalty by an exiled official profess acceptance of rural bliss, but actually are public statements of continued interest in politics. Now it will be clear why Fei Tangcheng had no room to deal with the *Red Cliff Rhapsodies* and had to ignore them.

The option for a private life entails a total negation of poetry if all poems are interpreted politically. When in act IV Su Shi again appears before the emperor, the emperor suggests that adversity should have improved his poetry and invites him to improvise a poem, but Su politely declines the request. When the emperor asks him to recite one of the poems he must have written at Huangzhou, Su replies by singing:

[*Zhe gui ling*]

Of course, I'd wanted to improvise poems like "White Snow" and "Bright Spring",

But what was only singing and joking about moon and breeze
Was turned into high treason and lèse-majesté.

(The emperor speaks:)

That was a momentary mistake on Our part. But isn't this sight with its orioles and flowers the right occasion for you to express your emotions in writing?

²⁹ *Op. cit.*, pp.4b-5a.

³⁰ *Op. cit.*, p.5a.

(The *mo* sings:)

Your Majesty orders me to chant about orioles and flowers—
This time I shall have to walk to the very end of the world!

(The emperor speaks:)

In earlier days, We remember, you accompanied Us in Our inner apartments
[until late at night] and We ordered that you be provided with “golden lotus”
candles, and palace ladies escorted you carrying them. At that time you wrote
a lyric to the tune *Manting fang* 滿庭芳 about it. Why not compose another one
for Us today?

(The *mo* sings:)

At this moment the censorate’s power is oh so great,
How could I dare to display my talents in the court of academicians?
Just a single line scares your insignificant subject to death!
These ladies of elegance and imperial concubines
Were the end of me, this author of elegies and writer of poems!³¹

The last five lines of this aria, and the preceding prose lines assigned to the emperor, would appear to refer to a tradition according to which Su Shi’s banishment was because of a flippant lyric about some high-ranking lady, which we will re-encounter in *Chibi fu*. The preceding two lines of this aria may well contain a hint of the later banishment of the historical Su Shi to the southernmost fringes of the empire. This in turn might imply that *Bian Huangzhou* is as much a deliberate fiction as e.g. *Qingshan lei*. Instead of being an attempt at a historically valid stage adaptation of Su Shi’s banishment, it may well have been written as a sketch of how Su Shi should have reacted to his banishment in order to avoid the eventual fate which his historical future had in store for him. If a writer is not sure to be understood correctly by those in authority, he should remain silent if he cares for his personal safety – such seems to be the eloquent plea of this play.

III. *Red Cliff Rhapsody*

Su Zizhan zuixie Chibi fu 蘇子瞻醉寫赤壁賦 (Su Zizhan, While Drunk, Writes the *Red Cliff Rhapsody*) has been preserved as an anonymous play in the *Gu mingjia zaju* 古名家雜劇, an extensive but incompletely preserved collection of *zaju*, edited in the early years of the Wanli period by Chen Yujiao 陳與郊.³² The earliest bibliographical reference to *Chibi fu* is found in the *Taihe zhengyin pu*. Its catalogue of anonymous plays lists a *Zuixie Chibifu*,³³ while its

³¹ *Op. cit.*, pp.8b-9a.

³² Fu Xihua, *Yundai zaju quanmu* (Peking, 1957), p.296.

³³ Zhu Quan, *Taihe zhengyin pu* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, Vol. III), p.42.

formulary includes two songs from the third act of *Chibi fu*.³⁴ The title is not found in the *Lu gui bu* or its sequel.

The contents of *Chibi fu* may be summarized as follows:³⁵

Act I, Scene 1. Wang Anshi (*chongmo* 冲末) has arranged a party to congratulate his friend Su Shi, who has recently been appointed as academician of Duanming Hall. Su Shi also has concluded an incomplete poem by Wang on wilting chrysanthemums by pointing out that these flowers do not shed their petals. Wang's wife will disguise herself as a musician in order to have a peek at this brilliant scholar.

Qin Guan 秦觀 (*wai* 外) enters and is welcomed by Wang, as is He Zhu 賀鑄 (*wai*). Su Shi (*zhengmo*) enters. He contrasts the continuous poverty of many students to his own recent rise to glory. He is welcomed by Wang and comments on the opulent surroundings.

Wang Anshi calls in the musicians, led by his wife (a *wai* dressed as *dan* 旦, heading the other *dan*), and has them perform behind a lowered screen. Following a poem by Su, Wang has the screen raised and Su praises the beauty of the girls. Su, who knows that Wang's wife is among the musicians, tricks her into baring her hands by saying that she has dropped one of her hairpins, and is astounded by her beauty. Su is now tipsy, and at the requests of the others he writes a lyric to the tune *Manting fang* in praise of Wang's wife and falls asleep. Qin Guan and He Zhu leave, and Su also departs when he wakes up. Wang Anshi is furious and wants Su Shi banished to Huangzhou, where chrysanthemums do shed their petals.

Act II, Scene 2. A palace eunuch (*wai*) announces that Su has been banished to Huangzhou on account of a memorial by Wang Anshi.

Scene 3. Shao Yong 邵雍 (*wai*) enters, together with Qin Guan and He Zhu. At the Ten Li Pavilion outside the city they wait for Su Shi.

The escorting warden (*waijing* 外淨 dressed as *xiezi* 解子) enters, together with Su's page. Because of the heavy snowfall, they stumble and fall on the slippery official road. They decide to wait for their charge and master.

Su Shi enters on horseback; he regrets that one drunken word has caused this drastic change of fortune and comments on the heavy snowfall. The warden and his page urge him to have a drink and their party stops at the Ten Li Pavilion. Su is greeted by his waiting friends. Su reflects that his long friendship with Wang Anshi has ended because of a woman and compares his fate to that of Han Yu and Li Bai. Shao Yong recites his genealogy to Su. Su reflects that his downfall is due to a henpecked husband and imagines his future carefree existence. Following his departure, his friends exeunt.

Wedge, Scene 4. The scene moves to Huangzhou, where prefect Yang (his role-type is alternately specified as *wai* and *jing*) enters with his warden Zhang Qian 張千, ordering him not to admit Su Shi to his office. Su Shi enters, requesting to see the

³⁴ *Op. cit.*, p.182, p.183.

³⁵ The *Gu mingjia zaju* edition of *Chibi fu* is photomechanically reproduced in *Yuan Ming zaju* 元明雜劇 (Peking: Zhongguo xiju chubanshe, 1958). The *Mai-wangguan chaojiaoben gujin zaju* also includes a copy of the *Gu mingjia zaju* edition. A modern type-set edition is provided in Sui Shusen 隋樹森 comp., *Yuanqu xuan waibian* 元曲選外編 (Peking: Zhonghua shuju, 1959), pp.767–81.

prefect on official business. Refused admittance, Su lashes out against the incompetence of the prefect and his lack of concern for the common people.

Act III, Scene 5. Huang Tingjian 黃庭堅 (no role-type specified) and the monk Foyin (no role-type specified) enter: they have hired a boat to enjoy the night of the fifteenth of the seventh month.

Scene 6. The boatman enters and sings a bawdy song, ridiculing an old man who has married a young wife.

Su Shi enters, together with Huang Tingjian and Foyin. [They board the boat which takes off]. Su Shi admires the autumnal riverscape and expresses his wishes for the well-being of the emperor. Foyin plays the flute, but is asked to stop by Su because its sound is too mournful. At the request of his companions Su Shi now writes a poem, the *Red Cliff Rhapsody*, and recites it to them. Su claims freedom from all cares and worries, and exits, followed by Huang Tingjian and Foyin.

Act IV, Scene 7. The palace eunuch enters: Shao Yong has died; the emperor wants to erect a stele to commemorate him, and as according to Yong's son Su Shi is the only person who knows Shao Yong's genealogy, Su has been recalled.

Scene 8. Su Shi enters. The Huangzhou spring sights fill him with despair. An imperial emissary arrives, is received and informs him of his recall to the capital. Prefect Yang comes on stage and enters unannounced into Su's house in order to offer his apologies. Su berates him at length.

Scene 9. At the capital, the palace eunuch welcomes the emissary and Su Shi. He informs Su that he will receive further promotions when the stele is completed.

In this play the four suites of songs (in the modes *Xianlü*, *Nanlü*, *Yuediao* and *Shuangdiao*) are all assigned to Su Shi, who also sings the *Wedge* (*Shanghua shi* and repeat).

As the above summary immediately makes clear, *Chibi fu* treats the same incidents in the life of Su Shi as *Bian Huangzhou*, but in a completely opposite manner. To begin with, every act in *Bian Huangzhou* has its counter-image in *Chibi fu*. Act I of *Bian Huangzhou* starts out with the enmity between Wang and Su, and it is Su's serious poetry which is a means for Wang to get rid of a political opponent. But act I of *Chibi fu* starts out with friendship between Wang and Su, which is shattered when Su writes a flippant lyric about Wang's wife. Moreover, in *Bian Huangzhou* personal antagonisms (Li Ding's hatred for Su Shi) are utilized in order to settle political issues, whereas in *Chibi fu* state power is abused to settle a personal feud: the relation between *gong* 公 (public) and *si* 私 (private) has been reversed.

No Song dynasty source is to be found for the plot of the first act of *Chibi fu*. The *Manting fang* lyric concerned, judging from its contents, was written in celebration of a banquet hosted by an unspecified *sikong* 司工 (minister of works). This title was only granted to Wang Anshi in 1085, just before his death, on the occasion of the accession of Zhezong. The text of the lyric may perhaps be translated as follows:

Fragrance hangs over carved plates,
 A cool springs from icy chopsticks:
 The painted hall is quite another sight!
 Filled with kind feelings our host
 Holds a banquet, brings out pretty girls.
 Glossy jade rubbed round into white necks,
 Tender lotus-root fibres
 Newly woven into sylphid skirts.
 When the duet is finished
 Empty eaves have moved the moon,
 Lingering rhymes still last and rise!

Among men
 Where to find them?
 The minister of works has seen them so often
 He may think them just common.
 Among his guests this foolish fellow
 Is confounded and bewildered.
 When one is told her golden hairpin has dropped
 Ten fingers are bared:
 Spring shoots, tender and long.
 To have seen them once
 Far surpasses Song Yu's
 Imagined rhapsodic description of Gaotang!³⁶

Actually, the whole anecdote seems very much out of character as Wang Anshi was well-known for his abhorrence of luxury.

During the Jin dynasty, as we learned from the conversation between Shizong and Yelü Li, there circulated a story to the effect that Su wrote a flirtatious song about the wife, an imperial princess, of his friend Wang Shen – but the tune of the lyric is not specified. On the other hand, Fei Tangchen, as we saw, suggests that Su Shi wrote a flirtatious lyric to the tune *Manting fang* about some palace ladies. Other early Yuan playwrights also refer to Su's problems because of a *Manting fang* lyric. Both Guan Hanqing's *Xie Tianxiang* 謝天香 and Shi Junbao's *Ziyunting* 紫雲庭 state that Su's banishment was caused by this single *Manting fang* lyric, but neither mentions in this connection the name of Wang Anshi.³⁷ The only other text to link this lyric specifically to Wang's wife is *Dongpo meng*, but that play, as we will see later, is best understood as a reaction to *Chibi fu*, while there are also other considerations that argue for a relatively late date. The possibility should therefore not be excluded that the plot of act I of *Chibi fu* is the invention of

³⁶ For the Chinese text of this lyric, see Tang Guizhang 唐圭璋 comp., *Quan Song ci* 全宋詞 (Peking: Zhonghua shuju, 1965), p.278.

³⁷ Cf. Yan Dunyi, *Yuanju zhenyi* (Peking, 1960), p. 741, and Luo Jintang, *Xian-cun Yuanren zaju benshi kao* (Taipei, 1960), pp.412–14.

its anonymous author. If not, he carefully shaped it to contrast with the opening of Fei Tangchen's work.

The song-suites in the second acts of *Bian Huangzhou* and *Chibi fu* show a remarkable similarity of content: the first halves of both are extended descriptions of heavy snowfall, containing a list of earlier exiled officials and their miseries, and they both conclude with a description of the joys of a simple country life. However, in Fei Tangchen's work the second act dealt with Su Shi's arrival in Huangzhou, where he is met by Ma Zhengqing, whom he did not know before, whereas in *Chibi fu* his friends see Su off when he departs from the capital. Moreover, in the coda of the song-suite in *Bian Huangzhou* Su places his trust in history: "Even though I have been banished all alone / I shall leave my high renown for all eternity."³⁸ In contrast, *Chibi fu* in this act turns Su into a repository of historical fact when Shao Yong recites his genealogy to him.

Bian Huangzhou's act III has its counterpart in *Chibi fu's* Wedge. Whereas Fei Tangchen's prefect Yang was one of Wang Anshi's cronies, *Chibi fu* introduces him as a former friend of Su Shi, acting on his own initiative. Moreover, Su Shi does not visit him to beg for personal aid, but to bring the miseries of the common people to his notice. The Wedge of *Bian Hangzhou* finds its counterpart in the first two scenes of *Chibi fu*, act IV. The public farewell party of *Bian Hangzhou* is replaced by the scene of prefect Yang sneaking into Su's house to offer his apologies, but whereas Fei Tangchen showed a forgiving Su Shi because Yang's offence was a personal matter, the Su Shi in *Chibi fu* cannot show such clemency because Yang's incompetence affects all the people in his charge. The fourth act of *Bian Huangzhou* finds its direct counterpart only in the short final scene of *Chibi fu's* act IV.

However, the contrast between *Bian Huangzhou* and *Chibi fu* goes much deeper than the contrast between individual acts and scenes. The general line of development in both plays as a whole turns out to be exactly opposite. *Bian Huangzhou*, as we saw, chronicled the retirement from public office and the option for a private existence, paralleled by a negation of poetry. *Chibi fu* shows how an extremely intelligent but overly self-confident intellectual, by his flippant lyrics, causes his own downfall and by his banishment is brought to a new awareness of the plight of the common people, as a result of which his poetry acquires a seriousness which it lacked earlier. Su Shi's resumption of office upon his recall is now a logical conclusion of the play, and the composition of the *Red Cliff Rhapsody*

³⁸ *Bian Huangzhou* (in Wang Jilie, *Guben Yuan Ming zaju*, Peking, 1958), p.5b.

its logical climax, because this *fu* testifies both to his unswerving loyalty and to the awareness of the relativity of everything. In this way, the explicit negation of poetry by Su Shi in act IV of *Bian Huangzhou* has its real counterpart in *Chibi fu*, act III, which combines a stage adaptation of the *Red Cliff Rhapsody* with a recital of its full text.

Like *Bian Huangzhou*, *Chibi fu* belongs to the subgenre of plays on “banished officials and orphaned sons”, but its anonymous author has overturned the meaning of the subgenre’s central event: exile is no longer an undeserved disaster but rather a “fortunate banishment”, benefitting not only poetry and posterity but first of all the banished official himself, who now, in the final song of the play, once he has been recalled to court, gratefully acknowledges the appropriateness of his punishment:

A moment of thoughtlessness
Made me write that fateful lyric.
I myself committed a drunken crime,
Truly it was fitting that I suffered punishment!³⁹

The above discussion, I hope, has made clear that *Bian Huangzhou* and *Chibi fu* are best understood in contrast. Even though we do not have precise information on the date of composition of these two plays, the safest guess would appear to be that *Bian Huangzhou* is the earlier work: we have earlier bibliographical references, the construction is simpler, and the emperor still appears on stage in person instead of being replaced by a palace eunuch. If *Bian Huangzhou* is indeed the earlier work, *Chibi fu* to all likelihood was written as a deliberate rebuttal, as a *fan'an* 反案 (reversal of the case). The peculiarities of its plot can then be seen no longer as a ragbag of popular lore, but may have to be interpreted as the deliberate inventions of a highly conscious author. Fei Tangchen’s seeming fidelity to facts created a Su Shi incapable of continuing his historical career, but the fiction of the *Chibi fu* prepared its Su Shi correctly for his further life.

Aoki Masaru 青木正兒, who thought the construction of *Chibi fu* commonplace, yet expressed a rather high opinion of its arias, which, according to him, almost attained the level of the works of Qiao Ji 喬吉.⁴⁰ Yan Dunyi 嚴敦易 has argued that the text preserved in *Gu mingjia zaju* as *Chibi fu* is not the anonymous *Chibi fu* recorded

³⁹ Sui Shusen, *Yuanqu xuan waibian* (Peking, 1959), p.760.

⁴⁰ Aoki Masaru, *Genjin zatsugeki josetsu* 元人雜劇序說 (in *Aoki Masaru zenshu*, Tokyo: Shunjusha, 1974), pp.425–26.

in the *Taihe zhengyin pu*, but actually a *zaju* by Zhao Shanqing 趙善慶, recorded in the *Lu gui bu* as *Zuixie Manting fang* 醉寫滿庭芳 (While Drunk Writing a *Manting fang*).⁴¹ Zhong Sicheng lists Zhao Shanqing in the category of “contemporary poets with whom I am acquainted and of whom I record their names and deeds and their writings”, so we may conclude that Zhao was active in the first half of the fourteenth century. The biographical notice reads:

Shanqing's style is Wenxian 文賢. He is a man from Pingle district in Raozhou. He is an expert diviner and has been appointed as the principal of the Yin-Yang school. (His style is also written as Zhao Wenbao 文寶, name Mengqing 孟慶.)

The various versions of the *Lu gui bu* credit Zhao altogether with eight plays, all of them lost. Zhong Sicheng's revised version is the only one to record *Zuixie Manting fang*.⁴² We may safely conclude that this play must have treated the incidents described in *Chibi fu*, act I, but how is not clear at all. Yan Dunyi's arguments (Su is drunk when writing the lyric; but not when writing the rhapsody; the *Taihe zhengyin pu* lists *Chibi fu* but omits *Zuixie Manting fang*) may be suggestive but are far from conclusive. Perhaps the best one can say in favour of Yan's thesis is that the dates of Zhao Shanqing fit in with our suggestion that the *Chibi fu* is later in composition than *Bian Huangzhou*.

Yan Dunyi's suspicions were probably aroused by the fact that the syllables *zuixie* in *zaju* titles more commonly precede the name of a *ci* tune to denote a romantic comedy. Both Li Wenwei's 李文蔚 *Cai Xiaoxian zuixie Shizhouman* 蔡蕭閒醉寫石州慢⁴³ and Zheng Guangzu's 鄭光祖 *Li Taibai zuixie Qinlouyue* 李太白醉寫秦樓月⁴⁴ are lost, but Dai Shanfu's 戴善夫 *Tao xueshi zuixie Fengguanghao* 陶學士醉寫風光好 (Academician Tao, While Drunk, Writes a *Fengguanghao*) has been preserved in three late Ming editions.⁴⁵ It treats the story of Tao Gu 陶穀, who, on a mission to persuade Li Yu 李煜 to surrender himself to the first Song emperor, sternly refuses the advances of the courtesan Qin Ruolan 秦弱蘭 but tries to seduce her when she presents herself to him disguised as a young widow, whereupon he writes for her a lyric to the tune *Fengguanghao*, which she sings the next day at a banquet, shaming him into fleeing to Hangchow, where they are later united in wed-

⁴¹ Yan Dunyi, *Yuanju zhenyi* (Peking, 1960), pp.741–42.

⁴² Zhong Sicheng, *Lu gui bu* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, vol. II), p.132. Cf. Fu Xihua, *Yuandai zaju quanmu* (Peking, 1957), p.265.

⁴³ Fu Xihua, *op. cit.*, p.22.

⁴⁴ *Op. cit.*, p.213.

⁴⁵ *Op. cit.*, p.199.

lock.⁴⁶ Su Shi, writing a lyric about a married woman masquerading as an entertainer, and Tao Gu, composing his song for an entertainer posing as a poor widow, are occasionally paired, e.g. by Jia Zhongming's Xiao Shulan 蕭淑蘭 in his play that carries her name.⁴⁷ Perhaps Zhao Shanqing's play rather exploited the romantic possibilities of its theme. And if the author of *Chibi fu* did not show Su Shi drunk in act III, he at least shows him and friends boozing.

IV. *Dongpo's Dream*

Huajian siyou Dongpo meng 花間四友東坡夢 (Four Friends Among Flowers: Dongpo's Dream) has been preserved only in the *Yuanqu xuan* 元曲選.⁴⁸ The contents of this play may be summarized as follows:

Act I, Scene 1. Su Shi (*wai*) has earned himself the hatred of Wang Anshi because of his opposition to Wang's New Laws. His pedantic wit has only increased Wang's enmity. Because of his *Manting fang* lyric he has been banished from the capital and is now on his way to Huangzhou. In Jiujiang, at a banquet offered by He Zhu, he has picked up the intelligent courtesan Bai Mudan (a descendant of Bai Juyi!) and he intends to take her along to Mt. Lu's Donglin Si 東林寺, hoping that she will seduce his friend Xie Duanqing 謝端卿, who as the monk Foyin is abbot of that temple, so that he will return to the laity.

Scene 2. A novice (*chou* 丑) enters with a broom. Foyin (*zhengmo*) enters and vaunts the joys of monastic life. He orders the novice to go to the temple gate and look out for visitors.

Su Shi enters, together with Bai Mudan (*dan*) and a servant. He orders her to stay on board their boat until he sends for her, and she exits. Su proceeds to the temple by himself, describing the spectacular mountain scenery in an elaborate tongue-twister. He meets with the novice and asks for Foyin. While the novice acts as an intermediary, he engages in an exchange of rhyming couplets with Foyin. Eventually he is invited in by Foyin. Su narrates his rise to glory, and his downfall, and the events leading to his banishment. Foyin states that both parties have been in the wrong. Su recites to him the *Manting fang* lyric.

Su Shi insists on having wine and meat. Foyin orders the novice to go out and buy some wine and a pig. The novice proceeds to do so. Su Shi insists on inviting a courtesan and the novice is ordered to fetch Bai Mudan, and he is literally overturned by her beauty. Bai Mudan greets Foyin, who praises her beauty, and Su has her offer wine to him. The novice does a song and dance routine. Eventually Foyin accepts the wine. Su urges him to take Bai Mudan as his wife and leave the monkhood but Foyin shows no interest. Su has Bai Mudan repeat the request but Foyin categorically refuses and exits. Su tells Bai Mudan to try again next day, when he will offer Foyin a return banquet.

⁴⁶ This summary is based on the edition in Zang Jinshu comp., *Yuanqu xuan* (Peking, 1958), pp.526–41.

⁴⁷ *Op. cit.*, p.1533. Also see W.L. Idema, *The Dramatic Oeuvre of Chu Yu-tun (1379–1439)* (Leiden: E.J. Brill, 1985), p.229.

⁴⁸ Zang Jinshu comp., *Yuanqu xuan* (Peking, 1958), pp.1234–50.

Act II, Scene 3. Foyin instructs the novice to be on the lookout for Su Shi who will shortly arrive to offer a return banquet, and voices his unshakable determination to stick to his religious calling.

Su Shi enters with Bai Mudan. They are welcomed by Foyin. Su urges him once more to return to the laity, marry Bai Mudan, and pursue an official career. Su vaunts the pleasures of such a life, but Foyin counters by pointing out what a misery a single lyric has caused Su.

Foyin retires to his abbot's room for a rest but has the novice take his place on the bed and exits. Su Shi instructs Bai Mudan to sneak into the abbot's bed and sing a song as a signal once the abbot has in fact slept with her. Bai Mudan sings her song and Su breaks into the room, where he is met by the re-entering Foyin, who tells him how he has been fooled. The novice and Bai Mudan exit.

Su Shi falls asleep and Foyin summons the four friends among flowers: willow, peach, prune and bamboo (four *dan*), and he instructs them to appear to Su in a dream, and exits. The foursome does so, they introduce themselves to Su as the four concubines of Foyin, sent to entertain him with song and dance. They thereupon perform a song and dance routine. When they request a poem, Su obliges by writing a poem on each of them separately and on all of them together. Su declares he will drink to the full.

Act III, Scene 4. The pine-tree spirit (*zhengmo*) enters: seeing that the four flower sprites are deluding Su Shi he wishes to chase them away. Su enters, together with the four friends. They are scared by the whirlwind marking a god's presence, and Su instructs them to hide themselves.

The pine-tree god orders Su to tell the four friends to appear. Su denies their presence. When the god has struck the table a number of times and searched the room, the four friends are found out. The god drives them away. Su implores him to leave behind at least one who may keep him company, but to no avail. Su goes to sleep again. The pine-tree god laments the fact that Su Shi, for all his intelligence (which has earned him the highest honours from the emperor), is still so much befuddled by wine and women, and exits.

In the early morning the novice announces a discourse on the Law by Foyin. Su Shi wakes up and decides to attend.

Act IV, Scene 5. Foyin (*zhengmo*) enters with monks, banners and gongs. He lights three candles, for the well-being of the emperor, the people, and the Law. The session is opened. Su Shi enters with Bai Mudan. To Su's question, phrased as a couplet, Foyin replies in a couplet. Su urges Bai Mudan to question Foyin. She complies by repeating her wish to marry him. Foyin parries all her questions and eventually she decides to become a nun, recites a poem, and exits.

The four friends enter. They each recite a couplet to Foyin, which is countered by him with a couplet chiding their behaviour during the previous night. Su Shi enquires who they are. Foyin replies that they were conjured up by him. Su feigns ignorance. Foyin explains to him how he has been led astray by his lust for wine and women: only now have the words of the *Mantingfang* lyric been fulfilled. Su now repents and expresses a desire to become his lay disciple. Foyin notes the fact that Su, for all his talents, now will have to listen to his lectures.

In *Dongpo meng* the role of Su Shi is played by a *wai*, whereas the *zhengmo* plays the part of Foyin in acts I, II and IV and the part of the pine-tree god in act III (the four song-suites employ successively the *Xianlü*, *Nanlü*, *Zhenggong* and *Shuangdiao* mode). However,

much care has been taken to flesh out the part of Su Shi by inserting in his speeches many poems and couplets, underlining his characterization as a poet. It may also be noted that the *chou*, as the novice, has a very substantial part.

As in the case of *Chibi fu*, the earlier historical and anecdotal materials do not offer a specific source for the plot of this play. Many Song dynasty *biji* 筆記 and *shihua* 詩話 record meetings of Su Shi with eminent monks. We also learn from Song dynasty materials that Su did not hesitate to take along courtesans when visiting Buddhist establishments, while his own concubine Qincao 琴操 became a nun. In later popular tradition, all the many eminent monks Su Shi associated with amalgamated into the figure of Foyin. The historical Foyin was the abbot of the famous Jinshan Si 金山寺 monastery and is recorded on occasion to have outwitted even the famous wit Su Shi.⁴⁹ As we have seen, Foyin was already a popular figure on the Jin dynasty stage, and *Dongpo meng*, act I, shows him again treating Su Shi to roast pork. Bai Mudan also figures in the *Yuanben mingmu*, but here it should be pointed out that in Yuan times this name was widely used as a typical one for a prostitute.⁵⁰ Moreover, the *Yuanben mingmu* title may rather refer to a stage version of the legend of the unsuccessful attempts by the courtesan Bai Mudan to seduce the immortal Lü Dongbin 呂洞賓, which was also adapted by an anonymous author as a *zaju* (now lost) entitled *Lü Dongbin xi Bai Mudan* 呂洞賓戲白牡丹 (Lü Dongbin Flirts with Bai Mudan).⁵¹ The wide popularity of this legend up to the present day suggests that the author of *Dongpo meng* borrowed the name of Bai Mudan from that work because his play also featured a courtesan who failed in seducing a holy man and ended up by becoming his disciple. Attempts to find the prototype of Bai Mudan in Qincao are not very convincing.⁵² Nowhere in *Dongpo meng* are any references to be found to previous incarnations of Su Shi and Foyin.

Foyin already made his appearance in *Chibi fu*, act III. There he is the flute player, whose music is filled with sadness because he is overcome by an awareness of the impermanence and futility of all human endeavour, and who has to be comforted by Su Shi. In

⁴⁹ The most relevant earlier anecdotes have been collected by Iriya Yoshitaka 人矢義尚, "Toba mu" 東坡夢, in *Shinagaku* XII (1947), pp.347–52, and Luo Jintang, *Xiancun Yuanren zaju benshi kao* (Taipei, 1960), pp.175–77.

⁵⁰ Feng Yuanjun 馮沅君, *Guju shuo hui* 古劇說彙 (Peking: Zuoja chubanshe, 1956), pp.313–15.

⁵¹ Fu Xihua, *Mingdai zaju quanmu* 明代雜劇全目 (Peking: Zuoja chubanshe, 1958), p.259, p.275.

⁵² See e.g. *Quhai zongmu tiyao* 曲海總目提要 (Peking: Renmin wenxue chubanshe, 1959), pp.54–56.

Dongpo meng the roles are reversed: now a deluded Su Shi is enlightened by Foyin. This makes *Dongpo meng* a deliverance play.⁵³ As such, it is rather exceptional. First of all, it belongs to the small group of Buddhist deliverance plays: *Renzi ji* 忍字記 by Zheng Tingyu 鄭廷玉, *Du Liu Cui* 度柳翠 (possibly) by Li Shouqing 李壽卿, and *Xiaotaohong* 小桃紅 and *Wu zhenru* 悟真如 by Zhu Youdun 朱有燾. The basic structure of these works, as in other deliverance plays, is a threefold confrontation between deliverer and disciple-to-be. A peculiarity of the Buddhist deliverance plays is that the final confrontation usually takes the shape of a formal Chan disputation.⁵⁴ *Dongpo meng* shares this pattern; the three confrontations successively dominate act I, acts II-III, and act IV, and the final confrontation is shaped as the conventional disputation. However, in these three confrontations the traditional functions of the deliverer and the disciple-to-be have been reversed. In almost all deliverance plays, the deliverer so to speak persecutes the disciple-to-be into enlightenment. Usually the deliverer is portrayed as a repulsive mendicant priest or monk, and his disciple-to-be avoids him at all costs. One variation on this pattern may be found in some late deliverance plays by Zhu Youdun (e.g. *Shenxian hui* 神仙會), in which eager converts await instruction from a teacher who is reluctant to impart the highest wisdom.⁵⁵ *Dongpo meng* presents yet another variation: the convert-to-be actively attempts to lure the holy man back to the laity. Su Shi tries to seduce Foyin by employing the most basic attractions of this phenomenal world: wine and women. His own fate is the best proof that his scheme is bound to fail, and Foyin has to enlighten Su and Bai Mudan to free himself of the nuisance they present to him. Throughout the Yuan and early Ming dynasties, the deliverance plays constitute a subgenre with its own remarkably rigid conventions; *Dongpo meng's* novelty in characterization therefore suggests a relatively late date. However, *Dongpo meng* should not only be related to the subgenre of deliverance plays. Bai Mudan's unsuccessful attempts to seduce Foyin are also clearly meant to contrast with Qin Ruolan's successful mission in *Fengguanghao*.

Throughout *Dongpo meng*, the action of the play is consistently contrasted to the cause of Su Shi's banishment, the banquet at Wang Anshi's, where the lust for wine and women caused Su to write his

⁵³ Chong-wen Shih, *The Golden Age of Chinese Drama: Yuan Tsa-chü* (Princeton, 1976), p.95.

⁵⁴ Cf. W.L. Idema, *The Dramatic Oeuvre of Chu Yu-tun (1379-1439)* (Leiden, 1985), pp.69-78.

⁵⁵ *Op. cit.*, pp.85-93.

fateful *Manting fang* lyric. The banquet offered by Foyin to Su Shi and Bai Mudan in act I and the return-banquet offered by Su in acts II-III are both meant to contrast, in opposite ways, with the party thrown by Wang Anshi. Su Shi, who caused his own downfall by his lust for wine and women, is foolish enough to tempt Foyin by the same means and fails. Next Foyin creates a dream vision of four beautiful girls to prove to Su the illusory nature of his delusions. If Wang Anshi attempted to keep his wife hidden and yet ruined Su Shi, Foyin swamps him with women in order to enlighten him. In the pre-final song of act IV Foyin therefore claims:

To this applies: out of kind feelings the host brings out pretty girls!
 No talk about: the minister of works has seen them so often-just common!
 There's no escape from: among the guests this foolish fellow is bewildered!
 Every single line fits,
 Every single line fits:
 Nothing departs from that one *Manting fang* song!⁵⁶

Dongpo meng presupposes the pre-existence of a well-established “*Manting fang* legend” as encountered in *Chibi fu*. Because the view on that event in both plays is practically identical, the most tempting hypothesis is to assume that *Dongpo meng* was actually written by an author acquainted with *Chibi fu*, both to contrast with that play and to supplement it by explaining how Su Shi, who in *Chibi fu*'s act I is deluded by wine and women, can have attained in its act III the superior wisdom of the truly enlightened.

However, the matter is complicated by the issue of authorship. The *Yuanqu xuan*, following the *Taihe zhengyin pu*, credits *Dongpo meng* to Wu Changling.⁵⁷ Jia Zhongming's expanded version of the *Lu gui pu* also lists *Dongpo meng* as one of Wu's works, so it is beyond doubt that a play of this title was around by the early decades of the fifteenth century, but the earlier drafts of Zhong Sicheng's catalogue ignore that title.⁵⁸ Zhong lists Wu Changling in the category of “Already deceased famous lords and poets of the former generation whose plays circulate in the world”, which suggests that he was active in the second half of the thirteenth century. Zhong's biographical information is limited to the notice that he “hailed from the Western Capital” (i.e. Datong). Zhong credits him with nine titles. Once upon a time it looked as if much of Wu's oeuvre had

⁵⁶ Zang Jinshu comp., *Yuanqu xuan* (Peking, 1958), p.1249.

⁵⁷ Zhu Quan, *Taihe zhengyin pu* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, Vol. III), p.37.

⁵⁸ Zhong Sicheng, *Lu gui bu* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, Vol. II), p. 109, p. 172 (note 332).

come down to us, but it may well turn out that no play by him has been preserved completely. The six-*zaju* cycle *Xiyou ji* 西遊記 was ascribed to Wu upon its rediscovery, but it is now clear that Wu's *Xitian qu jing* 西天取經 (Fetchng Sutras from the Western Paradise) is a different work, of which two suites may have been preserved.⁵⁹ The *Yuanqu xuan* credits Wu Changling with the authorship of *Zhang Tianshi duan fenghua xueyue* 張天師斷風花雪月 (Heavenly Master Zhang Judges Breeze and Flower, Snow and Moon), equating it with the *Taihe zhengyin pu* title *Chengouyue* 辰勾月 (The Mercurial Moon), but in view of the difference between the two titles and of signs of late editing in the text of *Zhang Tianshi*, few modern scholars accept this ascription; at best they regard *Zhang Tianshi* as a late and heavy adaptation of *Chengouyue*.⁶⁰

However, these plays and other titles listed under his name suggest that Wu Changling's forte was plays involving pageantry and special effects: large crowds and battle scenes, appearances of gods, ghosts and monsters, very much in the manner of the palace shows by early Ming court playwrights like Yang Ne 楊訥 and imperial princes like Zhu Quan and Zhu Youdun. If so, an anonymous play involving considerable pageantry, such as *Dongpo meng* with its four friends and the pine-tree god, could easily become associated with the Wu Changling corpus. This might explain the discrepancy between the earlier drafts of the *Lu gui bu* (ca. 1335–1350) and Jia's version (1422).

The matter of authorship is still further complicated by two factors. The first of these is the double listing of *Dongpo meng* in the *Baowentang shumu* 寶文堂書目, which records both a *Dongpo meng* and a *Huajian siyou Dongpo meng*.⁶¹ This double listing may be a simple oversight but it may also, since different editions of the same work are usually listed as a single title, denote the existence of two different versions, the one being an adaptation of the other. As the present text of *Dongpo meng* does show some signs of later rewriting,⁶² it might actually be such a later adaptation of the original play. The second factor is that the *Lu gui bu xupian* 錄鬼簿續編 credits Yang Ne with a *zaju*, the full title of which reads *Mudan jiao fengmo channa, Foyin shaozhu dai Zizhan* 牡丹嬌風魔禪衲佛印燒猪待子瞻 (The

⁵⁹ For a brief summary of this discussion, see W.L. Idema, *The Dramatic Oeuvre of Chu Yu-tun (1379–1439)* (Leiden, 1985), pp. 213–14.

⁶⁰ *Op. cit.*, pp. 41–42.

⁶¹ Chao Li 晁瑛, *Chaoshi Baowentang shumu (wai yizhong)* 晁氏寶文堂書目外一種 (Shanghai: Gudian wenxue chubanshe, 1957), p. 141, p. 144.

⁶² E.g. in act II the four friends sing a song to the tune *Yue'er gao* 月兒高 by Tang Yin 唐寅 (1470–1523), as pointed out by Yan Dunyi.

Beauty Mudan Deludes a Chan Monk; Foyin, Roasting a Pig, Treats Su Shi).⁶³ No play carrying this title has been preserved, but Yan Dunyi, arguing that this title fits the contents of *Dongpo meng* much better, has suggested that the available text might actually be (an adaptation of) Yang's work.⁶⁴ The suggestion may be interesting, but positive proof is in short supply. Personally I tend toward the conclusion that the *Dongpo meng* is a (certainly retouched) late Yuan/early Ming play, in the manner of, but not necessarily by, Wu Changling.

So it turns out that the three preserved *zaju* from the Yuan and early Ming dynasties which treat Su Shi all deal with the same period in his life: his banishment to Huangzhou, and all three plays question the relation between Su's poetry and wit and this experience. It would appear that these three plays were not written independently of one another, but that they are intimately interrelated. The above discussion has shown, I hope, that these plays are best understood in mutual contrast. Their authors did not provide faithful stage adaptations of historical facts or popular lore, but within the confines of their worldview, and of a specific literary genre (and subgenres) with its own conventions of variation, they explored and imagined alternatives of action. Most likely, each subsequent playwright conceived his own play in conscious contrast to the work of his predecessor. Such a contrast may involve the general development of the play, the characterization of its protagonists and details of all kinds. A full understanding of each play therefore requires not only a consideration of its place within its own subgenre, but also a comparison with other plays on the same subject, within or outside its own subgenre. As quite frequently only a single play on a given subject has come down to us even where we know that other *zaju* versions once existed, both its degree of novelty and its deliberate one-sidedness may often escape us. None of the three preserved *zaju* on Su Shi has established itself as a major literary work in its own right, but as a triad they testify very well to the inventiveness and versatility of the Yuan and early Ming playwrights.

V. Further Titles, Other Times

Two titles of *zaju* on Su Shi have not been discussed so far. Jin Renjie 金仁傑 wrote a play entitled *Su Dongpo yeyan Xihu meng* 蘇東

⁶³ *Lu gui bu xupian* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, Vol. II), p. 284.

⁶⁴ Yan Dunyi, *Tuanju zhenyi* (Peking, 1960), pp. 369–75.

坡夜宴西湖夢 (Su Dongpo's Night Banquet: A West Lake Dream). This play has been lost and no further indication as to its contents is available. The title itself might either suggest a romantic incident or another deliverance play, this time set in Hangchow. Jin Renjie was a Hangchow man, who had been a long-time friend of Zong Sicheng and died in the spring of 1329, at present-day Nanking, where he had been appointed to a minor official function. He wrote seven plays, of which only one (*Zhui Han Xin* 追韓信) has been preserved, as a Yuan block print.⁶⁵ The *Yeshe yuan shumu* 也是園書目, the catalogue of the library of Qian Zeng 錢曾 (1629–1699), lists the anonymous title *Su Dongpo wuru Foyousi* 蘇東坡誤入佛遊寺 (Su Dongpo by Mistake Visits the Foyou Monastery). As this play is lost and no further information whatsoever is available, nothing can be said about its contents or its date of composition.⁶⁶

The three preserved *zaju* have had little influence on the vernacular literature concerning Su Shi of the last century of the Ming dynasty. None of them was developed into a *chuanqi* 傳奇 or rewritten as a *huaben*. The existing vernacular stories on the conflict between Su Shi and Wang Anshi (*Jingshi tongyan* 驚世通言 ch. 3: *Wang Anshi sannan Su xueshi* 王安石三難蘇學士) or on the relation between Su and Foyin (*Xingshi hengyan* 醒世恒言 ch. 12: *Foyin shi sidiao Qinniang* 佛印師四調琴娘) are Ming compositions, written independently on the basis of Song dynasty anecdotes and contemporary lore.⁶⁷ However, the vernacular story *Wujie chanshi si Honglian ji*, surprisingly enough, exerted a considerable influence. The tale was not only rewritten by Feng Menglong as *Mingwu chanshi gan Wujie* 明悟禪師趕五戒 and included in his *Gujin xiaoshuo* 古今小說, ch. 30, but it also was adapted as a *zaju* by a certain Chen Ruyuan 陳汝元 under the title *Honglian zhai* 紅蓮債 (Red Lotus' Debt). In this *zaju*, the first two acts are devoted to the lives of Wujie and Mingwu, whereas the third and fourth acts deal with Su Shi and Foyin, and show how Foyin enlightens the initially stubbornly anti-Buddhist Su Shi and his concubines Zhao Yun 朝雲

⁶⁵ Zhong Sicheng, *Lu gui bu* (in *Zhongguo gudian xiqu lunzhu jicheng*, Vol. II), pp. 119–20; Fu Xihua, *Yuandai zaju quanmu*, pp. 221–23.

⁶⁶ Fu Xihua, *Yuandai zaju quanmu* (Peking, 1957), p. 366.

⁶⁷ For modern type-set editions of these two *huaben*, see e.g. Feng Menglong 馮夢龍 comp., *Jingshi tonggan* (Peking: Zuoja chubanshe, 1956), pp. 24–37 and Feng Menglong comp., *Xingshi hengyan* (Peking: Zuoja chubanshe, 1956), pp. 232–40. For a discussion of their dates and content, see Patrick Hanan, *The Chinese Short Story . . .* (Cambridge, Mass., 1973), p. 239, p. 243, and André Lévy, *Inventaire analytique et critique du conte chinois en langue vulgaire, Première partie, deuxième volume* (Paris, 1979), pp. 364–68, pp. 620–22.

and Qincao by disclosing to them their previous incarnations.⁶⁸ Chen Ruyuan is also the author of a *chuanqi* on the life of Su Shi, entitled *Jinlian ji* 金蓮記 (The Golden Lotus Candles). This southern play provides a rather full and detailed account of Su's career but makes some accommodations in view of the required happy ending. In *Jinlian ji* Chen Ruyuan also drew on *Wujie chanshi si Honglian ji* for some of his materials; as Qincao is seen as the reincarnation of Red Lotus she becomes one of the central characters of this play.⁶⁹

⁶⁸ Fu Xihua, *Mingdai zaju quanmu* (Peking, 1958), p. 169. The text of this play is included in Shen Tai 沈泰 comp., *Sheng Ming zaju erji* 盛明雜劇二集 (Peking: Zhongguo xiju chubanshe, 1958).

⁶⁹ Fu Xihua, *Mingdai chuanqi quanmu* (Peking: Renmin wenxue chubanshe, 1959), pp. 146–47. I have consulted the edition in Mao Jin 毛晉 comp., *Liushi zhong qu* 六十種曲 (Taipei: Taiwan Kaiming shudian, 1970).